complex. Some goons were looting Sikh-owned shops in that market and manhandling the owners. The same group was planning to loot the house of a Sikh officer in the first quadrangle of the Satya Marg D-I flats (the residential complex where I lived), who had recently returned from abroad and had a number of imported gadgets in his house. I immediately realized that this officer was Ranjit Singh Kalha, a 1965 batch IFS officer who had recently returned from London where he was posted as a counsellor in the high commission of India and was at that time posted as joint secretary (Americas) in the MEA. Incidentally, his flat was just below mine.

I did two things. I immediately called Kalha on the phone and, without disclosing the source of my information, told him that there was a plan to target his house. I asked him whether he had any weapons, and he told me that he had a 12 bore double barrel gun and a .32 bore revolver. Both were licensed but without ammunition. I then called Gary Saxena and requested him to send the SSB guard. Realizing the gravity of the situation and the likelihood of my flat also being targeted, I decided to shift out of my flat with my family and go across to my batchmate and close friend Sudhir Devare's flat in the second quadrangle and remain there till the arrival of the guard. We had come to know Sudhir, an IFS officer, and his wife Hema rather well when Sudhir and I were both posted at Gangtok.

Walking the 200m to Sudhir's flat felt like the longest distance I had ever walked. Lots of things came to my mind. I could visualize what might have been going through the minds of millions of Hindus and Sikhs who were forced to leave their homes in West Punjab, now part of Pakistan, and move to India in the wake of the Partition in 1947. And here was a government officer compelled to flee his home in a government colony in his own beloved country because he happened to be an easily identifiable turban-wearing Sikh, who had to be made to pay the price for the assassination of a popular prime minster. The new, less-than-a-day-old prime minister seemed to have abdicated his duty to protect the life, honour and property of thousands of Sikhs in the capital city and elsewhere, as he was mourning the death of his mother.